

Gold Fever!

Tom Massie's Fun, No-Hassle Guide to Finding Real Gold Across America

Introduction: Hi Friends, Tom Massie Here — Let's Catch Gold Fever Together!

Well howdy, folks! Tom Massie here — the lucky guy who got to host *Gold Fever* on the Outdoor Channel for over two decades, knee-deep in creeks with families just like yours, watching kids scream when that first flake hits the pan.

If you just binged *Gold Rush* or *Bering Sea Gold* and now you're itching to get out there yourself, I've got the biggest grin on my face right now. That itch? That's gold fever starting, and trust me — it's the most fun virus you'll ever catch.

I grew up with it. My dad, George “Buzzard” Massie, caught it back in the 60s and dragged me along on every trip. We started the Gold Prospectors Association of America in 1968 because we wanted regular families — moms, dads, kids, grandpas — to be able to go have a blast on the creek without headaches or locked gates.

Every week on the show, that was my mission: show you how easy and downright joyful this hobby is when you know the simple tricks to keep it hassle-free.

This book is me handing you those tricks on a silver platter (or should I say gold pan?). Where to start, what five tools to grab, the beginner-friendly spots that are wide open today, and a bunch of stories — the laughs, the big finds, and the “well, we learned quick” moments — so your first trip is nothing but sunshine, smiles, and color in your vial.

Because gold fever isn't really about the gold — it's about the creek running past your boots, the whole family digging together, and that magic second when somebody yells “I got one!”

Stick with me, and I'll make sure every trip is pure fun with zero worries — so you can keep catching the fever for the rest of your life.

So pull up a five-gallon bucket, friends. Let's go get you some gold!

— Tom Massie

Chapter 1: Gold Is Still Out There — And It's Waiting on Folks Just Like You!

Friends, every single time I talk to somebody new, they say, “Tom, ain't all the gold gone by now?”

I just laugh, pull the little vial out of my pocket, and show ‘em the pickers I found last Saturday afternoon.

There is still gold everywhere in these United States — tons of it. Rivers move it around, floods uncover fresh bedrock, and every year brand-new shiny shows up for regular folks with a pan and a dream. I’ve watched first-timers on the show pull out nuggets you could feel proud to put on a necklace.

The beauty of this hobby? You don’t need fancy equipment or a TV crew. A gold pan, a shovel, and a little creek water is still all it ever took.

My dad and I learned that early — we’d see a pretty stream, jump out of the truck, and start digging. Sometimes we’d fill our bottles and grin all the way home. Sometimes... well, let’s just say we learned there’s a right way to keep the fun going trip after trip.

The great news is we’ve still got the 1872 Mining Law on our side — the best deal prospectors ever got. In plain English: on a whole bunch of public land, everyday people like us have the right to go look for gold and keep whatever we find.

Here’s the easy breakdown I always gave on the show:

- **Hand panning and shoveling** → almost always smiles
- **Metal detecting or a small sluice box** → usually no trouble at all
- **Bigger gear** → just a couple simple rules and you’re good

Do it with a little common sense, and every weekend can be a gold weekend — no worries, no wasted days, just family and fun.

I’ll give you those simple rules straight — because the only thing better than finding your first flake is knowing you can go back next Saturday and do it again.

Now let’s talk about the one rule that’s opened more creeks for me than anything else...

Chapter 2: The Golden Rule That Beats Every Other Rule

Alright, here’s the single most important thing I can ever teach you, and I learned it the hard way so you don’t have to:

Private property is private — always ask permission first. Every single time.

Doesn’t matter if the place looks abandoned or the creek is calling your name. You find the owner and you ask nice.

Because nothing kills the fever faster than an angry landowner and a ruined day. Been there more than once in the early years, and I still turn red thinking about it.

But here's the part that'll make you smile: when you ask the right way, folks say YES way more than no — and half the time they end up showing you the honey hole themselves!

On the show we knocked on doors all across the country. Nine times out of ten we'd leave with a new friend and the best spot on the place.

Here are the exact two sentences that worked like pure magic for us:

“Hi there, I'm Tom. My family and I love panning for gold — just hand tools, no mess. Would you mind if we spent a couple hours on your creek today? We'll fill every hole and leave it cleaner than we found it.”

That's it. Smile, mean it, offer to share any nice pieces (most laugh and say keep it), and you'll be amazed.

One of my favorite days ever was in Georgia. Knocked on Mr. Johnson's door — big ol' farmer with arms like bridge cables. Used those two sentences. Ten minutes later he's in hip boots with us, telling stories about his granddad's two-ounce nugget from the '30s. We left with full pans, homemade pickles, and a standing invitation.

That's gold fever — it spreads to everybody it touches.

Sometimes they still say no, and that's okay too. Thank 'em, wish 'em a good day, and move on. Plenty of other creeks — especially when you know the spots that are already wide open and waiting (we'll get to that easy button soon).

Bottom line: treat folks right, ask every time, and you'll never run out of places to catch the fever.

Chapter 3: Federal Lands That Belong to All of Us — BLM & Forest Service Rules Made Simple

Well friends, if you're just catchin' the fever, here's the part that still gives me goosebumps after all these years: millions and millions of acres out West still belong to all of us — you, me, and every kid who's ever dreamed of finding shiny.

The Bureau of Land Management (BLM) and the U.S. Forest Service take care of some of the prettiest, gold-bearing dirt and creeks you'll ever see, and the door is wide open for regular families to go panning, detecting, and even running a little sluice — as long as we all play by a few simple, common-sense rules.

I've spent half my life on these public lands with the *Gold Fever* cameras rolling, watching kids and grandpas light up like Christmas morning. And let me tell you — there's nothing better than pulling off a dirt road, knowing you're 100% welcome and nobody's gonna run you off.

Here's the easy-peasy breakdown I always gave rookies on the show:

- **Just a gold pan, shovel, and maybe a pry bar?** Go anywhere that's open — no permit, no paperwork, just you and the creek making memories.
- **Metal detecting for nuggets?** Wide open on almost all BLM and Forest Service ground. My favorite way to hunt with grandkids!
- **Small sluice box or highbanker?** Usually perfectly fine too — just keep it “casual use,” meaning no big holes or torn-up hillsides.
- **Want to camp while you prospect?** You get 14 days in one spot (that famous 14-day rule), then move down the road a piece. Plenty of room to roam.

Now, steer clear of National Parks, National Monuments, Wilderness Study Areas, Wild & Scenic Rivers that are closed to mineral entry, and of course any tribal lands — those are always off-limits without special permission.

One quick heads-up while we're here, friends: even on these big public lands, some of the very best spots have active mining claims staked by folks who got there first under that 1872 law. The neighborly thing — and the legal thing — is to respect those claim markers and not dig on somebody else's stake without asking. I've always said, “There's plenty of gold for everybody if we treat each other right.” That's why having organized claims you can just show up and enjoy (no guesswork) is such a beautiful thing — we'll talk about that game-changer soon.

I remember one trip up in Oregon — crystal-clear creek, highbanker humming, color pouring into the box. Here comes a ranger in his truck and the new guy with us turns whiter than flour. Ranger looks everything over, sees we're doing it right, tips his hat and says, “Have a good one, folks!” Walked away grinning. That's the peace of mind I want for you and your family.

So grab that pan, load up the truck, and head West, friends — the gold's been waiting a hundred and fifty years for somebody just like you to come scoop it up.

Chapter 4: State Snapshots — What's Open, What's Tricky, What's Closed

Alright, friends, let's cut right to it — every state's a little different, just like every creek has its own personality. I'm gonna give you the plain-English rundown on the top dozen gold states we chased on the show. This is the quick-and-dirty version I wish somebody had handed me when I was starting out.

Hand panning with a shovel and gold pan? Almost always perfectly fine coast-to-coast on open public land or with landowner permission. Metal detecting? Usually wide open too. Small sluice box? Nine times out of ten you're smiling.

The big “it depends” is suction dredging and bigger equipment — that's where Mother Nature and the lawmakers get protective, and rules change faster than creek levels after a rain.

Here's the 2025 snapshot (and remember, this stuff shifts — we'll talk about the best way to stay 100% current in a minute):

- **Alaska:** The last frontier, friends! Hand panning, detecting, sluicing — go for it on most public land. Suction dredging needs an APMA permit from DNR, but if you're serious about the big north, Alaska still feels like the old days.
- **California:** Beautiful creeks, but suction dredging is still prohibited statewide (been that way for years). Hand panning and small sluices are fine under casual-use rules on open BLM and Forest Service ground — just no motors in the water.
- **Nevada:** Wide open for casual panning, detecting, and sluicing on BLM land (and there's a ton of it). Dredging is possible with permits if you jump through the hoops — Nevada's still prospector-friendly.
- **Colorado:** Panning and detecting are smiles all around on public land. Some rivers have fish habitat restrictions, and dredging is pretty limited these days — stick to hand tools and you'll be golden.
- **Arizona:** One of my favorites — tons of BLM ground, drywashing heaven, hand panning and detecting wide open. Dredging only where there's enough water and permits allow, but Arizona's nugget country for sure.
- **Oregon:** Hand panning and non-motorized sluicing are good to go. Motorized stuff (including most dredging) is under tight rules and moratoriums in salmon streams till at least 2026 — check the latest before you fire up the pump.
- **Idaho:** Recreational permit is easy and cheap for small-scale stuff. Suction dredges 5-inch or smaller are regulated but doable with the right paperwork — Idaho still lets you get in the water and have fun.
- **Montana:** Casual panning and detecting no problem on open land. Dredging needs permits and has stream restrictions — Montana's got that big-sky freedom with a side of common sense.
- **Washington:** Grab the free Gold and Fish pamphlet — that's your ticket for most panning, sluicing, and small dredging. Some streams are off-limits for motors, but Washington still has plenty of color for families.
- **Georgia:** Back East charm — mostly private land, so knock on doors like we talked about. Hand panning and detecting are fine with permission, and there are some public spots and club claims. No dredging headaches because there's not much call for it.
- **North Carolina:** Same story — private creeks, ask nice, and you'll find color. State parks and national forest have open areas for panning. The Cradle of American Gold still shines for beginners.
- **Alabama:** Private land rules apply — polite knock opens gates. Hand panning and small sluices are the way to go. We had some of our best family trips here finding flakes in red clay creeks.

Laws change quicker than a spring runoff, folks — one year it's open, next year there's a new fish rule. That's exactly why the smartest move my dad and I ever made was building the Gold Prospectors Association of America — so regular families always have the latest, state-by-state details in one spot (along with places you can just show up and dig, no guesswork).

But enough maps for now — let's get back to the creeks themselves...

Chapter 5: Rivers & Streams — Where Most of the Fever Starts

Ah, friends, pull up a rock and listen close — this is where the real magic happens. There's just somethin' about standing knee-deep in a rushing creek, cold water tugging at your boots, sunlight flashing off the ripples, that makes a man feel alive. That's where 90% of folks catch the fever for good, and it's where most of your gold is gonna come from too.

I've spent more happy days in moving water than I can shake a gold pan at — from the red-dirt creeks back in Georgia to the big glacier rivers up in Alaska. Rivers are Mother Nature's own gold factory: heavy shiny drops out behind boulders, in the inside bends, and on bedrock cracks while the lighter stuff washes downstream. Give me a good stream and I'm grinning like a kid on Christmas morning.

Hand panning? Wide open almost everywhere with legal access. Small sluice box or highbanker on the bank? Usually smiles all around. Metal detecting the gravel bars? Pure fun. But let's talk about the king of 'em all — suction dredging.

Man, there is nothing — and I mean nothing — like firing up a dredge, dropping that nozzle to bedrock, and watching chunky gold pile up in the box. The roar of the engine, the cloud of silt, the whole family taking turns on the nozzle... that's prospecting at its finest. Dad ("Buzzard"), my brother Perry, and I pulled over eight hundred ounces out of the Stanislaus River in California's Motherlode over just a couple summers back in the day. We'd camp on the riverbank, eat beans and pancakes, and come home with jars full of buttery gold. Best times of my life.

These days some states have put tough restrictions or moratoriums on dredging to protect fish. It still pinches the heart a little when I think about how many folks will never get to feel that thrill because of the red tape. Here's the straight scoop in 2025:

- **California** — still under the moratorium, no suction dredging allowed right now. Breaks my heart, but hand tools and sluices keep plenty of color coming out of those Motherlode streams.
- **Oregon & Washington** — heavy restrictions and moratoriums on most salmon streams (Oregon's runs till at least 2026). A few spots still possible with permits, but it's tough sledding.
- **Idaho, Alaska, Montana, and a few others** — still legal with the right permits! If you're willing to fill out the paperwork and follow the rules, there's nothing on earth like dredging bedrock. Do the homework, get the permit, and you'll be telling your own 800-ounce stories.

Quick East-vs-West note (like we talked about in Chapter 2): Back East the landowner almost always owns the creek bed and the gold, so knock first. Out West, on some bigger navigable rivers, the state might own the water and bed even if the banks are private — meaning the

minerals could still be open to prospecting under the 1872 law. But friends, I always asked permission anyway. Keeps everybody happy and the gates open.

Bottom line — start with a pan in moving water. You'll be amazed what you'll find with just a little patience. And if you fall in love with the roar of a dredge like I did, chase the places where it's still wide open. You won't regret it.

Chapter 6: Metal Detecting for Gold & Nuggets — Wide Open & Legal Fun

Well friends, if you want the absolute easiest, most fun way to catch gold fever without a single worry about rules or red tape, grab yourself a metal detector and let's talk.

I'm gonna let you in on a little secret: detecting for gold nuggets is my all-time favorite way to spend a day with the family — especially with kids or grandkids who aren't quite ready to get knee-deep in an icy creek. You just swing that coil slow and easy, listen for that sweet “beep-beep-BEEP,” dig a little scoop, and bam — there's a nugget smiling up at you. No water, no heavy buckets... and almost zero regulations to slow you down.

On BLM land, Forest Service ground, most state parks that allow it, old ghost towns, dry washes, even a lot of beaches — metal detecting is wide open for us regular prospectors. Just fill your holes, pack out your trash like any good gold hunter does, and you can hunt from sun-up to sun-down.

I've taken detectors from the red deserts of Arizona to the black-sand beaches of Alaska, and the only permit I ever needed was a smile.

My daughter Kia? That girl caught the detecting bug harder than anybody in the family. She's got the best ears I've ever seen — always swinging that detector like she was born with it.

One of the best days we ever put on film was out in the Southern California desert around Last Chance Canyon. Kia and I were just poking along those old tailing piles, sun beating down, having a ball. All of a sudden her coil screams — good solid signal. She digs down maybe six inches and pulls up a sweet little nugget, rough and yellow as butter. She looks up at me with those big eyes shining brighter than the gold itself and hollers, “Dad! I got one!” I darn near dropped my detector. We jumped around like we'd won the lottery, and that little piece still sits in a bottle on my desk today. That right there, friends — watching your kid find their first nugget — that's the real motherlode.

Detecting is perfect for beginners because:

- You can start with a solid machine for a few hundred bucks.
- It works where a gold pan can't — tailing piles, sagebrush flats, even old mining camps.
- Grandparents love it — no sore back from bending over a creek.

- Kids (and daughters like mine) love it because it's a real-life treasure hunt with headphones.

Just remember that Golden Rule from Chapter 2 — if it's private land or an active claim that isn't yours, ask first. But on open public ground or the claims set aside for prospectors? Swing away, friends.

I've watched more people get permanently hooked from one good detecting day than anything else. One beep, one nugget, and you're family for life.

Chapter 7: Permits, Plans of Operation, and Why Most Folks Never Need One

Alright, friends, let's talk about the part that scares a lot of new folks half to death — permits and paperwork. I'm gonna give it to you straight like I always did on the show: 99% of recreational prospectors never have to fill out a single government form. Never. Not one.

If all you're doing is hand panning, swinging a detector, running a little sluice box, or even a small highbanker on the bank, you're just following those casual-use rules we talked about on federal lands — you're good to go. No permit required. I've taken families out for decades with nothing but shovels and pans, and we've filled bottles without ever talking to a bureaucrat.

The only time the paperwork monster usually shows up is when you want to run a suction dredge or something bigger than "recreational." Even then, it's mostly just a Notice of Intent (a simple one-page form) or, in rare cases, a Plan of Operation if you're doing something that really disturbs the ground.

Here's the plain-English difference I always explained on camera:

- **Notice of Intent** → Basically a heads-up letter to the Forest Service or BLM saying, "Hey, we're gonna run a 4-inch dredge for a couple weeks, here's where, and here's how we'll leave it clean." Most of the time they stamp it and you're fishing bedrock the next weekend.
- **Plan of Operation** → Only for bigger stuff — like a commercial-sized dredge or excavator. That one takes longer and costs more, but again, regular families almost never need it.

I remember years ago up in Alaska we wanted to run an 8-inch dredge on a beautiful river. Filled out the state and federal forms, waited months, paid the fees... finally got the green light and pulled some gorgeous gold. Great trip, no doubt. But here's what hit me on the drive home: all that waiting and wondering, and right down the road was a GPAA claim where we could have just shown up, dropped in a sluice, and started finding color the same day. No forms, no delays, no stress.

That's the beauty of keeping it recreational — you get to spend your weekends finding gold instead of pushing papers.

If you ever do decide to step up to a dredge (and I hope you do, because there's nothing like it), just check the current rules for your state, fill out what's asked, and follow the guidelines. Do it right and the rangers will be your friends — I've had 'em stop by just to watch the gold pile grow in the box and wish us luck.

Bottom line, friends: for the kind of fun, family-style prospecting we're talking about in this book, permits are something you'll probably never touch. Keep it simple, keep it casual, and the gold will come.

But if you want to “permit-proof” your gold fever forever... well, hang on just a second, because the next chapter is the one that changed everything for my family and thousands of others.

Chapter 8: The Absolute Best Way to Never Worry About the Law Again

Well now, friends, lean in close because this chapter right here is the one that's closest to my heart. After all the talk about rules, permits, private land, and “is this spot okay?”, I'm fixin' to tell you about the single smartest thing my family ever did to make gold prospecting pure joy again — no headaches, no guesswork, no wasted weekends.

You see, back in the late 60s my dad — George “Buzzard” Massie — was plumb fed up. He'd drive hundreds of miles with me and my brother Perry riding shotgun, only to find another gate locked or a new sign sayin' “No Trespassing.” Good creeks were getting snatched up by big companies or just plain closed off to regular folks. Dad would cuss under his breath (quiet-like, so us kids wouldn't hear the worst of it), and we'd turn the truck around and head home with empty pans and sore hearts.

One day he slammed on the brakes, looked at me and said, “This ain't right. We're gonna fix this for everybody.”

And that's exactly what he did. In 1968 he started the Gold Prospectors Association of America — GPAA for short — so families like ours could always have places to go dig, pan, detect, sluice, highbank, and yes, even dredge when the rules allow, without ever having to wonder if we were breakin' some law we didn't know about.

I was just a young buck then, but I watched Dad build it from nothing — knockin' on doors, shakin' hands with ranchers, filing claims from Alaska clear down to Georgia. When I took over runnin' the show (and later the TV program), keeping that promise alive was my number-one job. It still is to this day.

Here's what GPAA does for regular folks:

- Hundreds of claims — thousands of acres — all across the country that members can just show up to with a membership card. Drive in, park, start diggin'. No knockin' on doors, no wondering if the gate's gonna be locked tomorrow.
- The famous GPAA Mining Guide — updated with the latest rules, maps, claim boundaries, and state-by-state breakdowns. It's the prospecting bible we wished we'd had back in the old days.
- The magazine, the local chapters, the big national outings where hundreds of families camp together and swap stories around the fire.
- And the best part — on a bunch of those claims you can run bigger gear (highbankers, even dredges where state law allows) without filing a single government form, because the association already took care of the heavy liftin'.

I can't tell you how many times on the show we'd roll up to a GPAA claim with a family who'd never found color in their life, hand 'em a pan, and an hour later they're hollerin' and huggin' because their pan's got flakes dancin' in it. No ranger worries, no angry landowners — just sunshine, laughter, and gold.

That's the fever the way it's supposed to be.

Dad's proudest legacy, and mine too, is knowing we built something that keeps the creeks open for moms, dads, kids, and grandpas who just want to make memories. If you're reading this and thinkin', "Man, I want that kind of freedom," well... you're closer than you think.

But enough about that for now — let's talk about the real reason we're all out there in the first place: gettin' the whole dang family hooked on this shiny bug.

Chapter 9: Family Gold Fever — Gettin' the Whole Dang Family Hooked (the Right Way)

Well now, friends, if there's one thing I'm prouder of than any jar of nuggets on my shelf, it's watching an entire family catch the fever at the same time. I always said gold fever is a family disease — and thank the good Lord there ain't no cure!

From the time my own young'uns were knee-high to a grasshopper, I had 'em out on the creek with me. My boys Brandon and Kael, and my daughters Aly, Kia, and Shae — they grew up with pans in their hands and dirt on their faces. We'd camp on the banks of GPAA claims up in Alaska, the whole bunch of us laughin' and diggin' while the midnight sun just kept shinin'. I'd show 'em how to feed the sluice box, classify the material, and work them rich bank runs where the gold likes to hide.

End of the day we'd do the big cleanup, and I'd let the kids do the honors. Kia'd swirl that black sand around, rinse it slow, and when them pickers started showin' up — bright yellow and chunky — she'd holler loud enough to scare the moose! One time she pulled a handful of fat flakes out of the box and looked up at me with those big eyes sparklin' brighter than the gold

itself. “Daddy, we’re rich!” That right there, folks... that’s the real treasure. Still chokes me up thinkin’ about it.

I brought families like that on the show every chance I got because I wanted you watching at home to see it ain’t just for rough ol’ buzzards like me and my dad. It’s for mamas who want a weekend away, wives who think their husband’s lost his mind till THEY find the first flake, kids who’ll talk about it for the rest of their lives, and grandpas who get to be the hero again.

And here’s the beauty — this hobby is one of the safest, most wholesome things a family can do together, especially when you’re doin’ it where you know you’re welcome. Calm creeks with easy access, no big equipment needed to start, just sunshine and laughter. Throw a picnic blanket on the bank, let the little ones splash and pan, and watch the magic happen.

I’ve seen shy teenagers who barely talk at home turn into chatterboxes when they pull their first color. I’ve seen marriages get a little stronger when husband and wife are knee-deep in the same hole, laughin’ at each other covered in mud. And I’ve seen grandkids hug their granddad’s neck so hard he can’t breathe because “we found GOLD, Papa!”

If you’re reading this and thinkin’ about taking your own crew out for the first time, do it. Start simple — a pan, a shovel, a bottle for the gold, and a spot where nobody’s gonna fuss at ya. Watch what happens. That fever spreads faster than gossip in a small town, and it’ll give your family stories you’ll tell for generations.

Because at the end of the day, the gold in your pocket is nice... but the gold in those kids’ eyes? That’s forever.

Chapter 10: Responsible Prospecting — Fill Your Holes and Keep the Fever Alive

Listen here, friends, before we go any further, I gotta talk straight with ya about something that’s been burnin’ in my heart since the first day I ever stuck a pan in a creek.

We’re the luckiest bunch of folks on God’s green earth — gettin’ to chase shiny in some of the prettiest country there is. But that privilege comes with a big ol’ responsibility. If we don’t take care of the land, the water, and the folks who own it or watch over it, the gates are gonna slam shut faster than a bear trap. And once they’re shut, they don’t open again easy.

I learned that lesson early. Dad drilled it into me: “Son, you leave every place better than you found it, or you don’t deserve to come back.” That’s the code we lived by, and it’s the code I preached every single week on the show.

Here’s the simple rules I want every one of you to tattoo on your brain:

- **Fill every hole you dig.** Doesn't matter if it's a detector scoop or a test pit — rake it smooth, stomp it down, scatter some leaves or rocks on top. Nobody should ever twist an ankle or see a moonscape because you were there.
- **Pack out every scrap of trash** — yours and anybody else's. I've filled many a trash bag with old beer cans and plastic bottles left by folks who didn't know better. Leave the creek cleaner than you found it, and landowners will love you for it.
- **Don't tear up the banks or the vegetation.** Stay on the gravel bars when you can, don't cut live trees, and if you move a rock, put it back where the fish expect it to be.
- **Run your equipment clean.** No petroleum leaks, no excessive silt, and always follow the reclamation plan if there is one.
- **Be quiet and respectful.** No blaring radios, no yelling across the canyon at midnight. We're guests in God's cathedral out there.

I've seen claims get closed forever because one knucklehead left a mess. I've also seen ranchers open brand-new stretches of creek because a family came through, filled every hole, picked up trash, and left a thank-you note and a jar of cookies on the porch. Guess which one keeps the fever alive for the next generation?

This ain't about being perfect — it's about being proud. When my kids were little, I'd make 'em police the area before we left. They'd groan at first, but by the time they were teenagers they were doing it without being told. Now they're teachin' their own young'uns the same thing. That's how we keep this hobby going for another hundred years.

Take only gold and pictures, friends. Leave only footprints.

If every one of us lives that way, there'll always be creeks waiting with open arms.

Chapter 11: Your First Trip — The Exact Plan I'd Use Today If I Was Starting From Scratch

Alright, friends, we've talked the talk long enough. Now let's walk the walk. You've got the fever burnin', you've got the basic know-how, and you're itchin' to get some real gold in your bottle. Here's the dead-simple, no-fail plan I'd follow today if I was a brand-new prospector with a family and a pickup truck. It's the same checklist I used on every single *Gold Fever* shoot for more than twenty years.

Step 1: Pick Your Spot (the easy way) Don't overthink it. Start close to home or a fun weekend drive. Google “[your state] gold prospecting” or flip back to Chapter 4 for the hot states. If you want the absolute simplest first trip with zero guesswork, get yourself access to organized claims (like the ones GPAA has waiting from Alaska to Alabama). Drive up, park, start digging — no knocking, no wondering.

Step 2: Check the Rules One Last Time Even if you're 99% sure, spend five minutes confirming. The GPAA Mining Guide or the BLM/forest service website for your area will tell

you exactly what's open today. Seasons, fire restrictions, dredging status — it's all there. Takes longer to brew coffee than it does to double-check.

Step 3: Pack the “Tom’s Five Essentials” Kit I could (and have) prospected with nothing but these five things and come home with color almost every time:

1. Gold pan (14-inch with riffles — green or blue so the gold shows up bright)
2. Folding shovel or army entrenching tool
3. Classifier screen (1/2-inch mesh to fit on your pan)
4. Snuffer bottle and vial for your gold
5. Small pry bar/crevice tool (for scraping bedrock cracks)

Throw in gloves, sunscreen, bug spray, plenty of water, snacks, and a trash bag (remember Chapter 10). Total cost if you're starting from zero: under a hundred bucks.

Step 4: Hit the Road Get to your spot early — gold likes morning light. Park legal, walk the creek or claim a bit, look for signs of old workings (tailing piles, stacked rocks). Find inside bends, bedrock cracks, or behind big boulders where heavy gold drops out.

Step 5: Dig, Classify, Pan

- Dig gravel from below the water line or in the bank run.
- Run it through your classifier to knock out the big rocks.
- Dump the classified material in your pan, submerge, shake side-to-side to settle the heavies, then tilt and wash off the light stuff.
- When you see black sand and (fingers crossed) yellow, slow down and tease it out with your snuffer bottle.

First pan might be all black sand. Fifth pan might have twenty flakes. Fiftieth pan might have a picker that makes you holler. That's prospecting — and it's addicting.

Step 6: If Somebody Official Rolls Up Smile big, kill the engine if you've got one running, and say, “Howdy! We're just out here enjoying the creek.” Show your map, your membership card if you've got one, or the printed rules that prove you're legal. Nine times out of ten they'll tip their hat and wish you luck. I've never once had a problem when I was doing it right and polite.

End of the day, fill your holes, pack out every scrap, take a picture of your vial, and drive home grinning. That first trip is gonna change everything — I promise you.

You're ready now, friends. You've got the plan, you've got the fever, and the gold's waitin'.

All that's left is one last thing...

Conclusion: Time to Catch the Fever — The Right Way

Well, friends, here we are at the end of the trail... or I guess I should say the end of this particular creek, because once the fever grabs you, there ain't no real end.

We've covered a heap of ground together — from that first itch you get watchin' TV to standing knee-deep in moving water with a pan full of color. We talked where the gold's still hiding, how to ask permission without getting run off, the public lands that are wide open, the states that'll treat you right, and every simple trick I know to keep your weekends full of laughs instead of headaches.

Most important, we talked about doing it the right way — fillin' holes, treating folks decent, and leaving the creeks clean so our kids and grandkids can do the same thing we're doing.

Because that's what this is really about. It ain't the ounces in the bottle (though Lord knows them ounces are sweet). It's the stories around the campfire, the kids hollerin' when they spot that first flake, the wife who swore she'd never get muddy holding up a picker and grinning bigger than you've seen in years. It's families making memories that'll outlast any nugget.

I've been blessed to live this life — from ridin' shotgun with my dad in the 60s to hosting *Gold Fever* and watching thousands of you catch the bug right along with us. And if there's one thing I want you to take from this little book, it's this:

You don't need a big rig or a PhD in mining law to find real gold and real joy. You just need a pan, a little know-how, and a place where you know you're welcome.

And friends... we've got those places waiting for you right now.

Since 1968 the Gold Prospectors Association of America has been keeping the gates open for regular families just like yours — from Alaska to Georgia and everywhere in between. All you gotta do is come join the family. One simple membership gives you the keys to hundreds of claims, the complete up-to-date Mining Guide with every map and rule you'll ever need, and a whole community of folks who'll treat you like kin around the campfire.

Head on over to www.goldprospectors.org, sign up today, and we'll send you that Mining Guide instantly. Your first trip — your first color — is waiting.

The gold's out there, friends. The creeks are runnin'. And the fever's calling your name.

Now quit reading and go catch it.

I'll see you on the creek.

— Tom Massie